

Pocketful of Palm

Once bitten by the mobility bug, Agent 001 sets out on the search for a Palm

After the laptop dream went up in smoke, I decided to think smaller—PDA smaller. I'd been waiting for an excuse to buy a PDA, and memories of my crushed laptop lust did just that. "Why don't you buy a PDA?" a vendor had suggested, pushing his laptops away from my hungry gaze. "It's got everything you need", he said, "and you won't have to worry about the battery dying, or your arm breaking".

That's about all the convincing I needed.

What Lamington Road is to hardware and software, Mumbai's Heera Panna shopping centre is to consumer electronics. Looking at the myriad of mobile phones on display, I spotted some handhelds. Upon asking, the salesman whipped out a cute little Sony Clie—a J22 with 16 MB memory at Rs 16,000. Unfortunately, it wasn't charged (none of the handhelds in his shop were), so I couldn't switch it on. When I asked to see something else, he showed me Palm's Tungsten. This was even smaller than the Clie, since the buttons at the bottom slide up to cover the scribble area when you're not using it. This was only Rs 500 dearer, and he recommended it over the Clie since it was 'original Palm' and had Bluetooth. It also features the newer version 5 of the Palm OS. You can use Word and

Excel files on it too.

More PC-like though, were the PDAs running Pocket PC that I found in the next shop. There was Compaq's 1910 for Rs 14,000, which featured a 100 MHz processor and 64 MB of memory. The salesman pointed out that only 47 MB was usable, since the pre-installed programs use up the rest. Though this did not come with a cradle for charging or synchronising with your PC, I liked it—it featured an expansion card, ran Word and Excel, and had a large sharp screen—quite impressive considering the price. He also had the newer 5550 model, which is fully loaded with a blistering 400 MHz processor, 128 MB memory, Bluetooth, WiFi and even a fingerprint reader for security. It also had a SIM card compartment that wasn't currently operational. All this for a hefty Rs 34,000! For a couple of thousands more, I could have the XDA O2—a full Pocket PC PDA with a working GSM phone. With it, I could surf the Net using GPRS directly. This particular dude also had a lot of accessories for iPaks—a keyboard for Rs 5,000, an additional 128 MB memory for Rs 2,600 and a 56k modem attachment for Rs 3,750.

I also came across a lone shop selling the Palm Zire71. "Fifteen thousand, five hundred", said the man when I pointed to the box in the show window. It's got 16 MB and a camera concealed by a sliding back. The screen was better than any under that name, but I still wanted to look further. So I moved on to Mumbai's business district, Fort.

Walking along, I spied a couple of Palms in a watch repairer's stall. I walked up and asked him if he sold PDAs too. Turns out he repairs them.

"So what typically goes wrong?" I asked. Power circuitry, normally, is the problem. "And the repair costs?" Though he was mostly non committal, claiming that he would have to see each case, generally he charges between Rs 500 and Rs 800.

I also encountered some overpriced vendors, selling Palm's older 515 for Rs 12,000 and the Tungsten for Rs 18,000. The 515 features the older Palm 4.1 OS and 16 MB of memory. Casio Pocket Viewers were the most popular devices—and for good reason. Prices for a 2 MB version start at Rs 3,200, and go up Rs 4,500 for a 6 MB version. These are pretty basic in function, offering the typical organisation tools (address book, appointments, etc.) and black and white screens. On the plus side, they do offer synchronisation with your PC.

Even secret agents have a heart, and mine was set firmly on the Zire71. The solid build,

the cool blue look, the cooler sliding camera and the coolest screen, all had me by my wallet strings. Since I was already reaching deep into my pocket, I reached a little deeper and forked out some extra for a 128 MB memory card for Rs 2,600; sure to come in handy once I got to collecting evidence with its camera! ■

ILLUSTRATOR: Mahesh Benkar



- Be sure to check everything in the shop—the grey market does not guarantee anything.
- Look at the user manual to see what accessories should be supplied. Don't come home to realise that you didn't get a cradle.
- As far as screens go, don't rely on specifications; consult your eyes.
- Pocketability is an important criterion. All the features are useless, if you leave it at home because it's cumbersome to carry.
- If you have a GPRS phone or laptop with Bluetooth, then look for Bluetooth on your PDA too. Don't ask why!

